

Leadership from Within

Character **First**

SCIENTIFIC FOUNDATION — EVIDENCE PYRAMID

Systematic Review Cotterill & Fransen (2016) — review of team leadership literature in sport: shared leadership (multiple players showing leadership behavior) correlates more strongly with team cohesion and performance than single formal leadership. *Psychology of Sport & Exercise*.

Multi-season study Fransen et al. (2020) — study over 2 seasons with 34 teams: teams with 3 or more informal leaders perform significantly more consistently than teams with only 1 formal leader. *Journal of Sport Sciences*.

Theoretical framework Côté & Gilbert (2009) — Integrated Definition of Coaching Effectiveness: effective leadership is not position-based but behavior-based; athletes who show servant leadership significantly increase team trust.

GUIDANCE "THE FIRST VOICE"

- 1 Explain what "The First Voice" means: during a time-out, before training, after a setback, someone who is the first to say something constructive. This is leadership in action.
- 2 This month, deliberately designate a player as "leader of the day." That person opens the warm-up, gives the pre-game motivational speech, or leads the cool-down. Rotate so every player gets a turn.
- 3 Briefly evaluate with the leader of the day after each session: "How did it feel? What was difficult? What will you do differently next time?"

COACH TIPS FOR THIS THEME

Tip 1: Deliberately broaden the concept of leader. Players who are quiet but always on time, always ready for a teammate, and never give up are also leaders. Name this explicitly. Not every leader speaks loudly.

Tip 2: The mentor moment works best when you do it too. Deliberately pair an experienced player with a newer player and give them a small shared task (leading the warm-up, summarizing a tactics discussion).

Tip 3: Name leadership behavior when you see it. "That was leadership" after a moment when a player cheered someone up or saved the atmosphere. Behavior that is named gets repeated.

⚠ Avoid the trap that leadership must always be loud and visible. This model excludes quieter, more introverted players. Actively name listening, being present, and being consistent as leadership behaviors too.

TIMING

- ☐ Introduction shared leadership: 5 minutes
- ☐ Group discussion informal leaders: 10 minutes
- ☐ Planning "Leader of the Day" exercise: 10 minutes
- ☐ Individual mentor moment completion: 2 minutes
- ☐ Closing and quote: 3 minutes